CINEMA

Going Behind the CAMERA

Actor **Boman Irani** talks about learning new skills before making his directorial debut with *The Mehta Boys*



Through his career spanning over two decades, Boman Irani has worked with some of the best directors in the Hindi film industry. And, every one of them has taught him something. "While on a film set, I'd spend time with them to understand why they choose to shoot a particular scene before others, or why the set was built in a certain way. From Raju Hirani to Raj & DK, they have all taught me something, whether it's a filmmaking technique or people management," says Irani, who after two decades in front of the camera made his directorial debut with *The Mehta Boys* recently.

The Mehta Boys, which premiered on Prime Video, is an intimate family portrait of a feuding father and son. Irani stars as the newly widowed and perpetually grumpy septuagenarian Mehta, while Avinash Tiwary plays his mopey architect son, Amay. Apart from directing and acting in the film, the 65-year-old has also written the film's script, along with Oscar-winning writer Alexander Dinelaris Jr. "Without Alex knowing, I made him my Guru. I met him in New York years ago and he really helped me sharpen the screenplay."

During this phase, Irani was also "reading books on cinema, biographies of directors and doing workshops". Irani understood that to direct, he would need to learn new skills. "You can't say 'I have 35 years of acting experience, so I automatically know how to make a film'." It helped that before his film

Not only has Irani acted in ***THE MEHTA BOYS*** and directed it, he is a co-producer and has written the film's script along with Oscar-winning writer Alexander Dinelaris Jr.